

Bombing North Vietnam

In the spring of 1965, the US Navy and Air Force shifted their efforts from narrowly focused, reprisal air strikes to the sustained bombing of military and civilian targets in North Vietnam in Operation Rolling Thunder.

◀◀ BEFORE

When Lyndon Johnson took office in November 1963, his national security advisers explained the conflict in Vietnam as a war of aggression rather than a civil war.

NSAM 273

National Security Action Memorandum 273 characterized the conflict not as a civil war between citizens of a single country, but as **a war of aggression** by one country (North Vietnam) against another (South Vietnam) involving an “externally directed and supported communist conspiracy.”

COLD WAR CONTEXT

This understanding of Vietnamese politics was formed in the **context of the Cold War** and laid the ground for future US policy toward Vietnam, determining the nature of America’s involvement.

Operation Rolling Thunder, the heavy bombing of North Vietnam by the United States Air Force and Navy and the ARVN Air Force, lasted from March 2, 1965, until November 1968. The bombing gradually increased in intensity, focusing first on military targets, then on transportation systems, petroleum storage, and industrial targets, as well as the civilian population centers of Hanoi and Haiphong.

Operational aims

Rolling Thunder had several goals: to disrupt the movement of men and war materiel from North Vietnam into the South via the Ho Chi Minh Trail; to damage North Vietnamese war-making ability; to undermine North Vietnamese civilian morale; and to incentivize North Vietnamese participation in diplomatic talks with South Vietnam. The US strategists hoped that sustained bombing of North Vietnam might precipitate its forces’ withdrawal from the South, thereby causing the Viet Cong insurgency to collapse and the South Vietnamese government to stabilize. None of that came to pass.